impacted ‘96,000 tribal households’ of central India and led to the creation of ‘20,000 Lakhpati Kisan families’ in a span of just three years. The initiative also led to interventions in ‘education, water, sanitation and hygiene, and nutrition’ along with the creation of ‘livelihood activities for 10,000 households’; and it created ‘2,540 irrigation structures’ bringing ‘12,000 acres under irrigation’.

In 2022, to tackle two growing crises—climate change and nutritional deficiency—TCI launched a new programme, ‘Zero-Hunger, Zero-Carbon Food Systems project’ with an aim to combat agricultural carbon footprints, while meeting nutritional needs of growing populations. India ranks third when it comes to greenhouse gas emissions and agriculture contributes nearly 20 per cent of this.

Seeking Foreign Technology

Ratan accorded critical importance to the employment of technology to increase the efficacy of the Tata Trusts’ initiatives, just as he had done with the Tata companies. He sought advanced technologies to fight poverty, improve health, education and sanitation for the poor in India—something that the government can less efficiently yoke.

To create a channel to access such technologies, in 2010, Tata Trusts contributed $50 million to the Harvard Business School. The objective of this grant was to encourage Indians to study at the university to ‘boost economic activity in India’ by imbibing the ‘world class management thinking’ of HBS to ‘positively’ impact ‘India through international companies participating in the Indian economy’.

The most important initiative Ratan took to seek appropriate technology for fulfilling his philanthropic goals was the collaboration the Trusts have forged with the Massachusetts Institute of Technology (MIT). Speaking on what made him choose the institute, Ratan said, ‘I think what drove me to MIT is, of course, the success of MIT in marshalling the technologies and the skills and the motivation of the students or the faculty into being that successful technology leader that the institution has been.’ ‘So, we decided that we would have a joint centre in India and in Cambridge’ to find a way to utilize new technologies for bettering the lot of the poor, Ratan adds.

To institutionalize the collaboration, the MIT Tata Center was set up with an endowment from the Tatas in 2012. It aims at pushing the frontiers of